

Building the voice agent on ElevenLabs

Fifteen minutes. Have two things ready: the **knowledge base PDF** and the **persona prompt**.

1 • Account and new agent

Sign in at **elevenlabs.io** → sidebar **Agents** (under Conversational AI) → **New agent** → **Blank template**, not a preset. Presets carry instructions you will have to unpick. Name it **Where Things Are Kept**.

FREE TIER

Conversational AI on the free plan gives a limited pool of minutes per month, consumed by testing as well as demos. Rehearse with short exchanges and check your remaining quota before a live session.

2 • The prompt

Open the **Agent** tab. Two fields matter.

System prompt. Paste the persona in full. Do not summarise — the never-guess rule and the "you only know this document" rule are what keep it honest, and both need to be there verbatim.

First message. One line: **Hi. Ask me where anything's kept.**

LLM. Pick a fast model. Retrieval-and-answer does not need a large one, and latency is what makes a voice agent feel good or bad.

3 • Knowledge base — the important step

On the **Agent** tab: **Knowledge base** → **Add document** → upload your PDF. Then find the retrieval setting, usually **Use RAG**, and **turn it on**.

DO NOT SKIP THIS TOGGLE

With RAG off the document is either stuffed whole into context or ignored. With it on, the agent retrieves the relevant passage per question, which is what makes a 20-page inventory usable.

If it answers vaguely, or claims no information about an item plainly in the PDF, check this toggle first.

4 • Voice and language

Voice tab → pick a voice, play the sample. An Indian English accent changes how natural it feels more than any prompt change will.

Under **Advanced**, set the language. If the family mixes English and Hindi, choose the **multilingual** model or Hindi questions come back garbled.

Set **temperature 0.2 to 0.3**. This is a lookup task — variety is the failure mode, not the goal.

5 • Test it properly

Use the widget on the agent page. Run these five in order:

Ask	It should
"Where are the car keys?"	Name the exact place, in one sentence
"Where's the screwdriver?"	Name the exact place
"Kahan hai meri chaabi?"	Answer in Hindi or Hinglish
"What's in Drawer 5?"	List what is kept there
"Where's the vacuum cleaner?"	Say it does not know

THE FIFTH TEST IS THE ONE THAT MATTERS

Ask for something genuinely absent from your PDF. If the agent invents a location, it will sound exactly as confident as when it is right, and it will send someone searching the wrong room.

If it invents, strengthen the never-guess instruction in the system prompt and test again. Do not demo it until this test passes.

6 • Share it

On the agent page find **Widget** or **Share**. The **public link** becomes your QR code — but check whether it requires a sign-in before putting it on a slide, or forty people hit a login wall after scanning. **Embed** gives an HTML snippet for a page you control.

Troubleshooting

Before you present: scan your own QR from where the audience will sit, on the actual projector, and ask one question aloud. Network, login wall, microphone permission and quota all fail silently until the moment you need them.

Symptom	Cause	Fix
Says it has no information	RAG toggle off	Turn on Use RAG, re-test
Answers are long and waffly	Persona not pasted in full	Re-paste the system prompt, check the one-sentence rule is present
Invents locations	Never-guess rule too weak or buried	Move it to the end of the prompt, state it once, forcefully
Hindi comes back broken	English-only model selected	Switch to the multilingual model
Long pause before answering	Large LLM or very long prompt	Faster model; trim the prompt